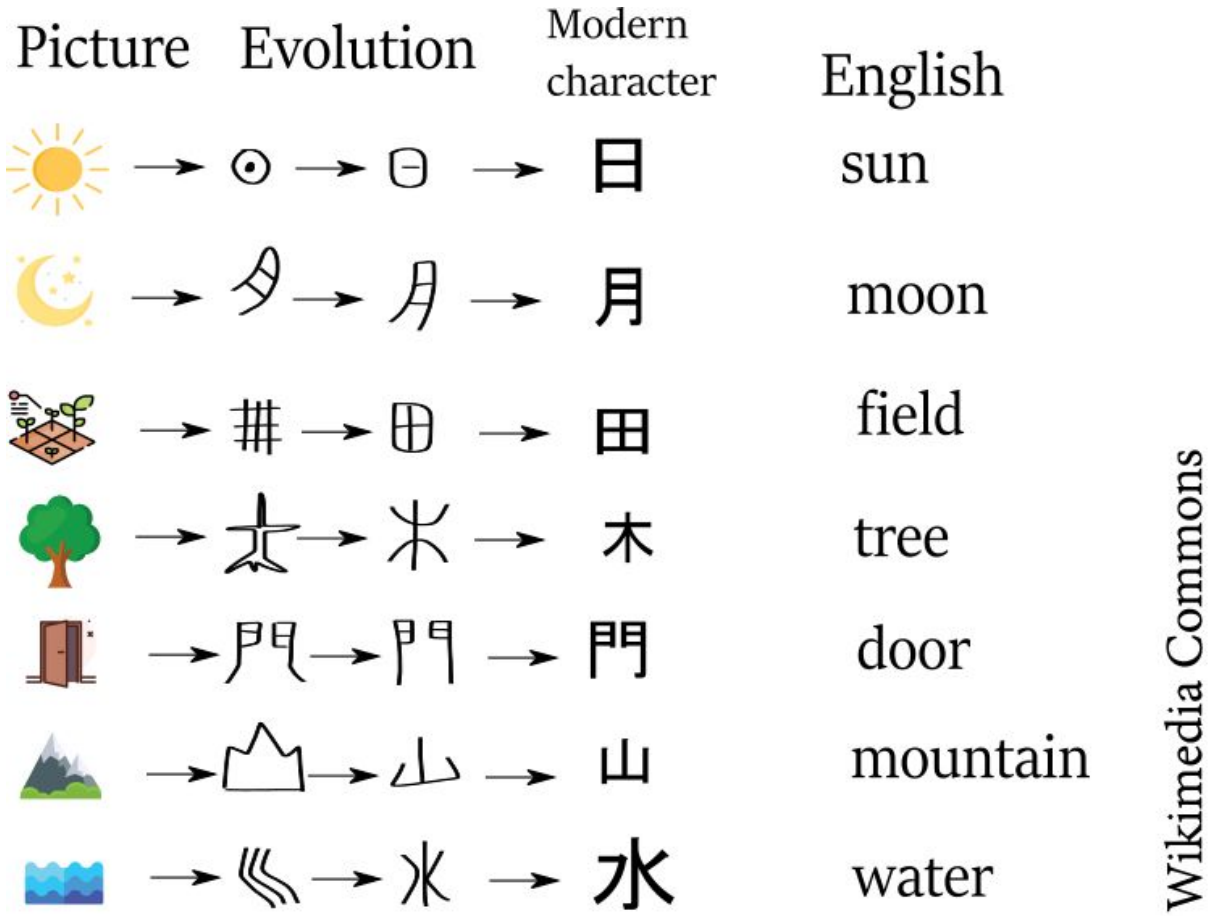


The image shows how the characters for sun, moon, cultivated field, tree, door, mountain and water have evolved from pictograms into ideograms.

There are some other aspects of the Chinese script which are worth noting. As Chinese civilization evolved and became more complex, so did the language. A single ideogram could convey a singular object or idea, so a way had to be found to make the script capable of conveying more diverse and complex ideas. The device of complex characters was adopted by combining two or even three characters together, to represent a new or more complex phenomenon. One part of the character could be a defining ‘radical’, indicating the character or nature of the object it describes. For example, an original character for animals may be used as a radical for all things that are ‘wild’. Thus, the characters used to denote the many hostile tribes on China’s periphery all carry the animal radical. Another part of the ideogram may only be a phonetic device to indicate the sound of the word,